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200 Wins, Two Coaches, One Culture

After 200 wins and a 2020 state title, Erik Vanags and Jeff Hinebaugh step away from Mariemont boys soccer together. (dek option)

By Chase Beach

Plain = Chase **"Quotes"** = Erik, Jeff, Luke, Quinn *Blue italic = Claude*
765 words

On August 20, Mariemont beat Ross 6-0, and Erik Vanags got his 200th win as head coach of Mariemont boys soccer, the most in the program's history. Only two other Mariemont coaches have reached 200: Tom Crosby, with 215 wins in football, and Steve Peterson, with 203 in lacrosse. Erik is now in that company, and that's worth writing about. This fall is also his last on the sideline, and Jeff Hinebaugh's.

200 is an extremely hard number to get to as a head coach in boys high school soccer. *The Ohio High School Athletic Association's boys soccer record book doesn't even list 200. It starts at 250 wins, and only 36 coaches in state history have made it.* Since starting as head coach in 2011, Erik has won more games a season (13.1) than any of the Cincinnati coaches in that record book. *Vanags reached 210 on October 31, beating top-seeded Oakwood 3-0 in the district final. He led the Warriors to an undefeated 23-0 Division III state championship in 2020. He was named Ohio's coach of the year in 2015 and 2020.*

"Those two guys, they are freaking legends in the game," Erik said. "I don't look at us as in that pantheon or category." They didn't feel worthy of being in the same conversation of those legends, but it's just them being them. Erik is incredibly humble, it's always about the team. *Win 200 nearly slipped by him.* "I think Lisa (Erik's wife) knew. I didn't know," he said. "She made sure to get a picture of Jeff and I."

Erik believes him and Jeff are a package deal, a one-two punch. "Everybody always calls me the head coach," Erik said. "I'm like, Jeff's been a part of every decision." *Jeff has coached with the program for 23 years without taking a salary,* and Erik asked me not to call him a volunteer. "Volunteer, you think, oh, it's part time," he said. "The day we lose at the end of the season, that night we're together planning the next season."

Jeff is selfless, always encouraging and never negative, very similar to Erik. *In Erik's first preseason, the two each looked up the same opponent on an obscure soccer database.* "We both were like, did we just become best friends?" Erik said. "One of the best parts is you get to work with

your best friend." All of it has the same through line: they're on the same page as not only coaches, but people.

"We'd love to tell you it's winning," Erik said. "It's really not." I do believe him. What he cares about is developing young freshman boys into graduating senior men. Jeff said, "I have never heard (Erik) talk about any kid as a kid he doesn't like." Erik put it this way: "If you build the culture and you build the relationships, the success comes as a result of that."

Luke Brothers, who scored twice in the 2020 state final, still remembers what Erik told the team after it. "I always remember Erik, after the 2020 state win, saying, 'Don't let this be the defining point of your life,'" Brothers said. "I carry that with me for every new accomplishment or milestone." Erik's coaching is still playing out for his players six years later.

I'll never forget, on the first day of my freshman year in 2007 (Erik's first year teaching), he talked in what seemed to be an Irish/Scottish accent. History class. I knew it was going to be very entertaining. He told me that every year he says he's not going to do it but ends up doing it. He really cared about you as a person, not just your test score.

Quinn Budig graduated in 2011 and was in my class. "Coach Vanags and Coach Hinebaugh have been pillars of the Mariemont soccer program and community for years," *he said.* "Their passion for the game and belief in every athlete have helped countless players succeed on the field, but their greatest impact has been in shaping them into men of character off it."

"I will stay involved with Mariemont soccer, just not as a coach," Jeff said. "I'm always going to be a fan, a supporter." *Erik said the program is in a great spot.*

Mariemont is a special place with special people who not only live in Mariemont, but teach in Mariemont, and take the time to coach in Mariemont.

When I asked Erik what he would say to every player he has coached, he said, "I love ya, and I hope you're doing well."

Open before sending

- **Confirmed by Chase (Nov 1):** the program record, the 2011 start as head coach, Luke's two goals in the 2020 state final, "the program is in a great spot," the "freaking legends" quote is Erik's, and Jeff's 23 years. The teaching line is out.
- **Win total:** 210 after the Oct 31 district final against Oakwood. If Mariemont wins in the regional, update the number before the Crier goes to print.
- **Pace line:** checked against all five Cincinnati coaches in the record book: Erik 13.1, Basalyga 13.0, Cummins 12.1, Mees 11.3, Bagley 10.2, and Randy Hurley about 9.6 (29 seasons at Moeller, 1987 to 2015, worked out in `research.md`).
- **Erik:** OK with "his last on the sideline" as worded? Don't use "goodbye for now."
- **Photos:** 06, 21 and 09 from Lisa (`photos/lisa-vanags.md`).